How to Write Suspense

By James Pinkerton

INTRODUCTION

What editor ever said, "Jeez, this script or chapter is just too funny, can we fix that?" Okay, if you're writing Handmaid's Tale or a Hallmark movie, they might say that. But in comedy, when have you ever stopped hunting for additional ways to make a story funny?

You can't just start forcing awkward jokes on characters or interrupt the plot to insert a string of one-liners, but a funny story needs to stay funny from beginning to end, right? So, here's an idea (insert ominous music "DUM, DUM, DUM") add suspense! Make the story bigger, scarier, add close calls, raise the stakes, get characters screaming and running, throw a dead body in there!

I see you are here today for James Pinkerton's Master Class: How to Write Suspense. (make a cringy face, then recover) It will be worth every penny! You'll learn how to inject blood-curdling hooks into every nook and cranny of your writing by someone who believes he/she is an expert! On to the first lesson!

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PINKERTON: **(Pg 258-262)** *(in an over-the-top, Master Class fashion)* Lesson 1, General Suspense Tips. The opening sentence is essential to a great suspense novel. It lets the reader know what the story's going to be about. *(expansively reading)* ***"John crossed over to the living room and lit a cigarette."***

Note how I have successfully introduced a character, a location, AND an action. Now let's crank up the suspense! ***"John crossed over to the living room and lit a cigarette.*** *(beat)* ***Or did he?"***

Doubt sets in. Our reader begins to question everything he or she has come to believe. Who is this John character? Can we really trust him? How can we really trust anybody? Chilling questions. Luckily, you don't have to answer them. Remember, great suspense lies in what you **don't** tell the reader.

Having placed the seed of doubt, we quickly move onto something else, distracting them. *(Ah ha!)* ***"John then went to work and nothing happened."***

This is a perfectly acceptable follow-up sentence, right? Wrong! This sentence isn't suspenseful at all. Let's try that follow-up sentence again: *"**John went to work.** (with great intonation and facial expression) **His day was a roller-coaster ride of intrigue and mystery."***

Did you see what made the "right" sentence suspenseful and what made the "wrong" sentence utterly worthless? *(Self-satisfied smirk)*

Lesson 2: Writing The First Chapter -- [Listen to] the following opening paragraph and try to locate where the suspense is coming from: *(with an obvious speech impediment, leaving out all the "R's")*

"The gunman adjusted his gay hat as he powled the misty ooftops, knowing his pey would show soon. Sweat stuck to his shit as he contemplated what he must do. The one-eyed man who had killed his fathe would finally pay the pipe."

(shivers with the thrill) An excellent opening to a great suspense novel! Where are all the R's? Is it a typographical error? Does the writer simply not like R's? Or are there mysterious deeds at play, and are the R's somehow involved? All of these questions spiral through a reader's mind as they find themselves in the taut grip of *(beat)* suspense.
In the next paragraph, we release this grip: *(Lightning crash)* **"The one-eyed man had stolen all the R's."**

Goosebumps, yes? Why? Because that was great suspense! Lightning is so suspenseful it's not even funny. Use it for everything! Lightning makes the reader notice whatever happened before the lightning. Remember, a suspense novel should start with a very suspenseful opening paragraph then release the suspense in the second. After this, *(waving off the thought)* you just write the rest of your book. The reader knows what kind of powerhouse suspense writing to expect, and your work is done.

Lesson 3: Writing Suspenseful Dialogue – [Listen to] the following dialogue. Watch for the "end parts" of the sentences. These are the parts where you're going to fit most of the suspense in! *(Pinkerton plays all characters with intense over-acting)*

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JANET: ***I never thought you'd be capable of murder, I've known you since the first grade. You've never harmed a fly.***

JOHN: ***Maybe that's true. Maybe it's not true. Maybe I've harmed lots of flies. You don't know me, Janet.***

JANET: ***Or do I? I know you're not capable of murder, John. Sure, maybe flies. I'll give you that. But people? That's stupid.***

NARRATOR: ***Then Janet saw an enormous bloody knife on the table.***

JANET: ***(reacts)*** ***Is this knife yours, John?***

JOHN: ***No, I'm pretty sure it's not mine.***

JANET: ***Are you lying to me, John?***

JOHN: ***No, probably not.*** ***(Lightning crashes)***

PINKERTON*:* Egad! Is John a murderer? Possibly! That's the thing – who knows? Good suspense dialogue should crackle off the page. Keep the reader on their toes by leaving out important details, locations, names, even events integral to the plot. Remember, the more the reader has to guess, the more powerful your writing becomes. *(said with authority even though this is obviously wrong)*

Lesson 4: Ending Your Suspense Novel -- A good suspense novel must have a surprise ending to leave the reader completely dumbfounded. If you've done your job up to this point, then the reader should have no clue what's happening, who your characters are, or what it is they're so worried about. Time to make them jump out of their seats!

"John and Janet had finally solved the murder. It had been some other guy all along. They were sitting down to a delicious lasagna that Janet had baked when suddenly . . ."

ENDING OPTION 1 is GOOD

". . . . Janet's head exploded! Janet had been injected with a toxin that explodes heads. John stopped eating his lasagna. *(beat)* ***Or did he?"*** *(Waits awkwardly for audience applause, then continues)*

ENDING OPTION 2 is BETTER

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". . . a big bomb dropped on the house, killing both of them, but mostly Janet. The bomb had been launched in Iraq because of a war there, but the guidance system had shorted out, so it went over to Janet's place instead and flew right into her head. John had a mouthful of lasagna at the time and was flabbergasted. Everyone else was flabbergasted, too. "We never saw that coming," they said. *(Waits awkwardly for audience applause, then continues in the most animated fashion)*

ENDING OPTION 3 is SUSPENSETASTIC!

. . . a murderer walked in the house!

"Oh no, a murderer!" John said as he stopped eating his lasagna. The murderer chased John all through the house and murdered him while Janet escaped. She ran outside and flagged down a policeman who was driving by.

"There's a murderer in my house!" Janet said.

"He's not in your house," said the policeman. "He's ME!" Holy *moly*! The policeman was the murderer! He murdered Janet. ***(Lightning crashes)*** *(Pinkerton bows repeatedly as if to rounds of applause from a packed audience)*

Great suspense writing is not easy. But with a lot of practice, you will, I assure you *(beat)* NEVER be as good as I am.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARDS

2010 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
IN State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
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